Chapter 5

Raghu and the Rain

Rain Song

Little clouds, so dark and grey,
Please come back to us today.
The fields are dry, the wells are low,
Bring the rain to help seeds grow.

Raghu is a farmer in a village in Maharashtra. Every year, in the hot months of April and May, the land in his village becomes very dry. The grass turns brown and the well water goes down. Raghu and his family wait for the monsoon rains, which usually come in June.

While they wait, Raghu gets his field ready. He ploughs the field with his two bullocks to make the soil soft and loose. He mixes cow dung manure into the soil to make it rich. He keeps good seeds of jowar ready in a cloth bag.

Raghu waits for the rain because his crops need water to grow, and his village has no canal to bring water to the fields. Without rain, the seeds would not sprout.

At last, one day in June, dark clouds filled the sky. The rain came pouring down. The children danced in the rain, and the whole village smelled of wet earth. The next day, Raghu sowed his jowar seeds.

Soon, tiny green plants came up all over Raghu's field. He was very happy. He pulled out the weeds and watched his plants grow taller every day.

But one evening in August, the sky turned very dark. A strong wind began to blow, and along with the rain came hailstones, small balls of ice falling from the sky. The hailstones beat down on the young plants and broke many of them. The next morning, Raghu saw that a part of his field was damaged. He felt very sad.

Then his neighbours came to his field. "Do not worry, Raghu," they said. "We will help you." Together they planted new seeds in the damaged part of the field. Raghu had helped them many times before, and now they were helping him.

That evening, the village people met under the big peepal tree. They decided to dig a pond to store rainwater. "Next time the rains are late, the pond will help all of us," said the village head.

Let's talk

1. Why did Raghu wait for the rain?
2. What happened to the crops after the hailstorm?
3. How did the neighbours help Raghu?

New words

monsoon - the season of heavy rain in India
hailstones - small balls of ice that fall like rain